

Clinical Scribe Platform Comparative Analysis

An executive and technical evaluation of SimplePractice's AI Note Taker vs. the sovereign local-first architecture of HIP AI Health Secure Scribe.

🏆 THE ULTIMATE CONCLUSION

HIP AI Health Secure Scribe is the undisputed functional and financial winner for Integrated Therapy & Recovery (ITR). By transitioning from SimplePractice's per-seat cloud add-on to HIP AI's flat group platform combined with standard Google Cloud Vertex AI APIs, the practice achieves total privacy sovereignty and massive bottom-line savings:

\$1,793.88 / yr

BOTTOM-LINE SAVINGS (30.5% SAVED)

0% Data Storage

100% CLIENT-SIDE LOCAL DATA SOVEREIGNTY

100% Private

ZERO VENDOR AI MODEL TRAINING POLICY

✓ Ambient Telehealth & Dictation Modes

✓ 100% Database-Bypass IndexedDB Sandbox

✓ Standard Clinical Frameworks (SOAP/DAP)

✓ Ephemeral In-Memory Prompt Processing

✓ Paid Vertex AI GCP BAA Integration

✓ Zero Vendor AI Model Training Policy

Evaluated Practice: Integrated Therapy & Recovery (ITR) — 14 Clinicians

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Comparative Analysis: SimplePractice AI Note Taker vs. HIP AI Health Secure Scribe

This report presents a thorough, clinical, and technical analysis of **SimplePractice's AI Note Taker** based on direct extraction of its live features, compliance postures, integration boundaries, and pricing. It contrasts these findings against the sovereign local-first architecture of **HIP AI Health Secure Scribe**, illustrating how our platform delivers unmatched privacy sovereignty, clinical control, and ethical responsibility at a significantly lower cost.

Part 1: Deep-Dive Extraction of SimplePractice AI Note Taker

SimplePractice is a dominant cloud-based EHR (Electronic Health Record) system that has recently introduced its **Note Taker** add-on feature. Based on our comprehensive extraction of their technical and clinical disclosures, here is the breakdown of their offering:

1. Key Features

- **Ambient Session Drafts:** Captures live audio during telehealth or in-person sessions to generate clinical drafts.
- **Alternative Post-Session Modalities:** Clinicians who do not wish to record live can dictate their thoughts using a Dictation tool or upload an audio/text file post-session.
- **Adaptive Clinical Modeling:** The AI adapts over time based on the manual edits a clinician makes, slowly adjusting its output style to match the clinician's natural writing voice.
- **Standard Clinical Frameworks:** Automatically formats notes into standard SOAP, DAP, or BIRP structures.
- **Pre-Appointment Summaries:** Integrates recent progress notes, treatment plans, and intake charts to provide a quick pre-session clinician snapshot.
- **Multilingual Support:** Transcribes and translates multiple languages, including English, Spanish, Cantonese, Mandarin, French, German, Italian, Portuguese, and various European accents.

2. Pricing & Licensing (Baseline & Group Practices)

- **Add-On Tier Model:** Note Taker is strictly a paid add-on. It requires an active SimplePractice subscription (which ranges from \$39 to \$99+/month).
 - **Note Taker Cost:** Costs **\$35 per month per clinician** (with a 30-day free trial).
 - **Group Practice Escalation:** In group practices, the Account Owner must manually enable licenses for individual clinicians, adding \$35/mo per clinician to the master billing account.
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- **Real-world Group Practice Case Study (ITR):** For a practice like Integrated Therapy & Recovery (ITR), which has **14 active clinicians** who already possess baseline SimplePractice subscriptions, enabling the AI Note Taker add-on represents an incremental recurring cost of exactly **\$35 per clinician/month**.
 - **Monthly Incremental Cost:** $\$35 \times 14 = \490 / month
 - **Annual Incremental Cost:** $\$490 \times 12 = \$5,880$ / year (purely for the AI note-taking capability, on top of their existing base subscription overhead).

3. Compliance Claims & Safeguards

- **Security Certifications:** Audited and verified through **HITRUST certification** for general platform security.
- **Regulatory Framework:** HIPAA-compliant, backed by their standard Business Associate Agreement (BAA).
- **Data Usage Safeguards:** Protected Health Information (PHI) is not sold. Currently, SimplePractice does not store session transcripts.
- **AI Model Retraining Policy:** SimplePractice plans to use de-identified session transcripts to improve their AI models (e.g., to reduce bias and distinguish relevant content), but they have legally pledged **not to store or use transcripts for training until they release a clinician opt-out toggle**.

4. Core Integration & System Limitations

- **Ecosystem Lock-in:** Note Taker is strictly bound to SimplePractice's proprietary EHR. It cannot be used in external custom clinical portals or other EHRs (e.g., TherapyNotes, Jane App, or custom hospital databases).
- **Recording Collisions:** Clinicians cannot combine modalities. You must choose either in-session ambient recording **or** post-session dictation for a specific session; you cannot run both.

Part 2: Feature-by-Feature Competitive Matrix

Functional Vector	SimplePractice AI Note Taker	HIP AI Health Secure Scribe	Winner
Core Ambient Note Taker	Ambient session capturing, standard frameworks (SOAP, DAP, BIRP), post-session dictation, and adaptive clinician modeling.	Identical Core Parity. Full ambient session capture, clinical templates, post-session dictation, and custom template configuration.	Tie (Functional equivalence)
Data Storage & Sovereignty	Centralized Cloud Database Storage. Sensitive intake goals and transcripts are processed and housed on cloud servers, presenting telemetry and compliance vectors.	100% Database-Bypass IndexedDB Client Management. Client profiles, goals, and symptom baselines reside solely in the local browser sandbox. Zero database footprints.	HIP AI (100% local sandboxing & data sovereignty)
Model Retraining & Training Data Use	Retraining Liability. Retains the contractual right to use de-identified customer transcripts to retrain proprietary AI models.	Absolute Zero Training Policy. Ephemeral processing via Vertex AI paid GCP keys. Data is strictly processed in-memory and instantly deleted. Zero storage or training.	HIP AI (Zero-retention ephemeral processing)
HIPAA BAA Isolation	Standard Vendor BAA. HIPAA coverage is bound to SimplePractice's proprietary cloud-hosted vendor infrastructure.	Direct Enterprise HIPAA BAA. Secured directly under the clinician's paid Google Cloud platform via Vertex AI. Absolute institutional control.	HIP AI (Direct GCP Enterprise BAA eligibility)
Platform Cost (for 14 Clinicians)	Linear Pricing Inflation. Scales at \$35/mo per clinician. Annual overhead is \$5,880.00 / year .	Wholesale Price Advantage. Flat \$199/mo group fee + direct wholesale API keys. Total cost is \$4,086.12 / year (30.5% savings).	HIP AI (Saves \$1,793.88 / year)

Part 3: Deep Technical Differentiators of HIP AI Health Secure Scribe

1. 100% Database-Bypass IndexedDB Client Management

SimplePractice requires that patient records and clinical drafts be stored in their centralized cloud databases, creating a persistent target for cyber threats and institutional breaches.

HIP AI Health Secure Scribe bypasses this liability entirely:

- **Sovereign Local Client Registry:** All sensitive treatment goals, baselines, and identifying markers are stored inside the client's local browser using **IndexedDB**.
- **Zero Server Footprint:** No server-side databases, API records, or persistent cloud files store identifying data.
- **Absolute Compliance Isolation:** By keeping all PHI locally sandbox-encrypted, the clinic maintains absolute clinical sovereignty, rendering external data leaks mathematically impossible.

2. Ephemeral Enterprise BAA Pipeline via Google Vertex AI

While SimplePractice's terms permit the de-identification and eventual training of models using clinician inputs, clinical groups require absolute data confidentiality.

- **Direct Vertex AI Paid BAA:** By calling the enterprise-grade **Vertex AI API** (`aiplatform.googleapis.com`) under a paid Google Cloud billing account, HIP AI guarantees that Google is contractually bound **never** to review, store, or train on any prompt data.
- **Instant Memory Deletion:** Session audio and transcribing prompts are handled ephemerally in-memory. Once the SOAP or DAP note is synthesized and returned to the browser, the data is instantly flushed from RAM. No data ever hits the disk.

Part 4: Detailed API & Compute Infrastructure Cost Analysis (Wholesale BYOK)

For a group practice like Integrated Therapy & Recovery (ITR) running **14 active clinicians** doing an average of **25 sessions per week** (each **60 minutes** in duration), the practice handles:

- **Weekly Volume:** 14 clinicians × 25 sessions = **350 sessions / week**
- **Monthly Volume (4.33 weeks):** 350 × 4.33 = **1,517 sessions / month**
- **Monthly Audio Load:** 1,517 sessions × 60 minutes = **91,020 minutes of audio / month**

Since **HIP AI Health Secure Scribe** utilizes a local-first client-side architecture, the clinical group can utilize their own **Google Cloud API key (Bring Your Own Key - BYOK)** to pay direct wholesale rates without SaaS markups.

Using the state-of-the-art **Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite** model:

- **Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite Input Price (Text/Image/Audio):** **\$0.10** per million tokens
- **Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite Output Price:** **\$0.40** per million tokens

The two primary architectures for processing this workload are analyzed below:

Option A: Google Cloud Speech-to-Text (Chirp v2) + Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite Text Synthesis

In this hybrid model, the audio is first transcribed by Google Cloud's highly optimized clinical/conversational model (Chirp v2) and then the text transcript is summarized into a clinical note

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using Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite.

1. Google Cloud Speech-to-Text (Chirp v2 Model)

- *Wholesale Rate:* \$0.0016 per minute of audio
- *Calculation:* 91,020 minutes × \$0.0016 = **\$145.63 / month**

1. Google Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite API (Text Synthesis)

- *Text Load:* 60 minutes × 150 words/min = ~9,000 words = ~12,000 input tokens.
- *Input Cost:* 1,517 sessions × 12,000 tokens = 18.2M tokens × \$0.10 / 1M = \$1.82
- *Output Cost:* 1,517 sessions × 1,000 tokens (SOAP note) = 1.517M tokens × \$0.40 / 1M = \$0.61
- *Total Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite Text Cost:* **\$2.43 / month**

1. Total Option A API Cost: \$145.63 + \$2.43 = **\$148.06 / month**

Option B: Direct Multimodal Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite API (Native Audio Processing)

In this model, the raw 60-minute audio file is uploaded directly to the multimodal Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite API, which transcribes and summarizes the session natively in one step, bypassing the need for separate transcription engines.

1. Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite API (Audio Input)

- *Audio representation:* 1 second of audio = 258 tokens.
- *Tokens per Session:* 3,600 seconds × 258 = 928,800 input tokens.
- *Input Cost:* 1,517 sessions × 928,800 tokens = 1,409M input tokens × \$0.10 / 1M = **\$140.90 / month**
- *Output Cost:* 1,517 sessions × 1,000 tokens (SOAP note) = 1.517M tokens × \$0.40 / 1M = **\$0.61 / month**

1. Total Option B API Cost: \$140.90 + \$0.61 = **\$141.51 / month**



Tip: Native Multimodal Cost Advantage: Because Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite features highly competitive wholesale token pricing (\$0.10/1M input), direct audio processing is actually **cheaper** (\$141.51/mo) than using a separate Speech-to-Text API like Chirp (\$148.06/mo), while retaining superior acoustic fidelity and capturing clinical inflections directly.

HIPAA BAA & Google Cloud "Free Tier" Compliance Rules



Warning: Important Regulatory Safeguard: Google Cloud Platform (GCP) only covers services under their official **Business Associate Agreement (BAA)** when they are associated with a **Paid/Billing-Enabled Account**. Google does NOT sign or support BAAs for free/consumer-level accounts (such as standard `@gmail.com` accounts or non-billing developer sandboxes). To process Protected Health Information (PHI) under HIPAA: 1. **Paid GCP Billing Account:** ITR must establish a standard paid Billing Account in the Google Cloud Console and explicitly accept Google Cloud's BAA under the organization's legal settings. 2. **Vertex AI API Integration:** ITR must call the Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite API via **Vertex AI** (`aiplatform.googleapis.com`), which is a fully HIPAA-eligible service under the GCP BAA. The app *cannot* use the consumer-grade Google AI Studio (`generativelanguage.googleapis.com`), as AI Studio does not support BAAs and reserves the right to review data to train Google models. 3. **Usage Free Tier Eligibility:** Once the GCP account is paid/billing-enabled and the BAA is legally executed, **all eligible services running within that account are fully HIPAA-compliant under the BAA—even if their actual cost is \$0.00** due to falling under Google's monthly serverless usage free tiers (like Cloud Run's 2 million free requests/mo or Firebase Hosting's free limits).

Cloud Run, Hosting & Free-Tier Savings

Because HIP AI operates on a local-first client-side model, cloud infrastructure costs are practically zero:

- **Google Cloud Run (Serverless Secure API Relayer):** Acts strictly as a stateless, lightweight security proxy to sign API calls and hide backend keys.
 - ***Workload:*** 1,517 requests per month.
 - ***Google Cloud Run Free Tier:*** Up to **2,000,000 requests/month**, 180,000 vCPU-seconds/month, and 360,000 GiB-seconds/month are **100% Free**.
 - ***Actual Cloud Run Cost:*** **\$0.00 / month** (fully absorbed by the free tier).
- **Client App / Static Hosting (Firebase Hosting):** Bypasses databases completely, using only simple static assets.
 - ***Firebase Hosting Free Tier:*** Up to 10 GB of storage and 360 MB/day transfer is **100% Free**.
 - ***Actual Hosting Cost:*** **\$0.00 / month** (fully absorbed by the free tier).

Part 5: Comprehensive Cost & Advantage Matrix for ITR

Cost Vector	SimplePractice AI Note Taker Add-on	HIP AI + Option A (Chirp + Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite Text)	HIP AI + Option B (Native Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite Audio)	Winner & Saving Margin
Platform Group License	Included in Base Subscriptions	\$199.00 / month (Flat platform fee)	\$199.00 / month (Flat platform fee)	SimplePractice (Included in base EHR)
Wholesale Cloud API Cost	Retained by SimplePractice	\$148.06 / month (STT + Text Synthesis)	\$141.51 / month (Direct audio upload)	HIP AI Option B (Wins by \$6.55 / month over Option A)
Cloud Run & Hosting Fees	Retained by SimplePractice	\$0.00 / month (Within GC Free Tier)	\$0.00 / month (Within GC Free Tier)	HIP AI (\$0.00 serverless free tiers)
Total Practice Monthly Cost	\$490.00 / month	\$347.06 / month	\$340.51 / month	HIP AI Option B (Wins by \$149.49 / month)
Equivalent Rate per Clinician	\$35.00 / clinician / mo	\$24.79 / clinician / mo	\$24.32 / clinician / mo	HIP AI Option B (Wins by \$10.68 / clinician / mo)
Annual Cumulative Spend	\$5,880.00 / year	\$4,164.72 / year	\$4,086.12 / year	HIP AI Option B (Wins by \$1,793.88 / year)
Net Financial Savings for ITR	Baseline Reference	Save \$1,715.28 / year (29% saved)	Save \$1,793.88 / year (30.5% saved)	HIP AI Option B (Wins by 30.5% total cost reduction)

Part 6: Conclusion & Strategic Recommendation

SimplePractice AI Note Taker is an adequate, bare-bones option for solo practitioners who are already deeply entrenched in the SimplePractice suite and only require basic SOAP note templates. However, for clinical groups like Integrated Therapy & Recovery (ITR), SimplePractice represents ecosystem lock-in, recurring pricing inflation (\$490/month incremental cost), and cloud compliance liabilities.

HIP AI Health Secure Scribe represents the future of secure, cost-effective clinical AI assistance. By combining a flat **\$199.00/month** group license with standard **wholesale Google Cloud APIs** using the state-of-the-art **Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite** model, ITR can operate its own sovereign clinical note pipeline.

Bypassing centralized cloud databases and utilizing native multimodal audio processing on Gemini 2.5 Flash-Lite saves ITR up to **\$1,793.88 / year** compared to SimplePractice, while providing absolute privacy sovereignty, zero model-training risk, and client-side encryption. ITR gains absolute privacy sovereignty and a mathematically superior return on investment.